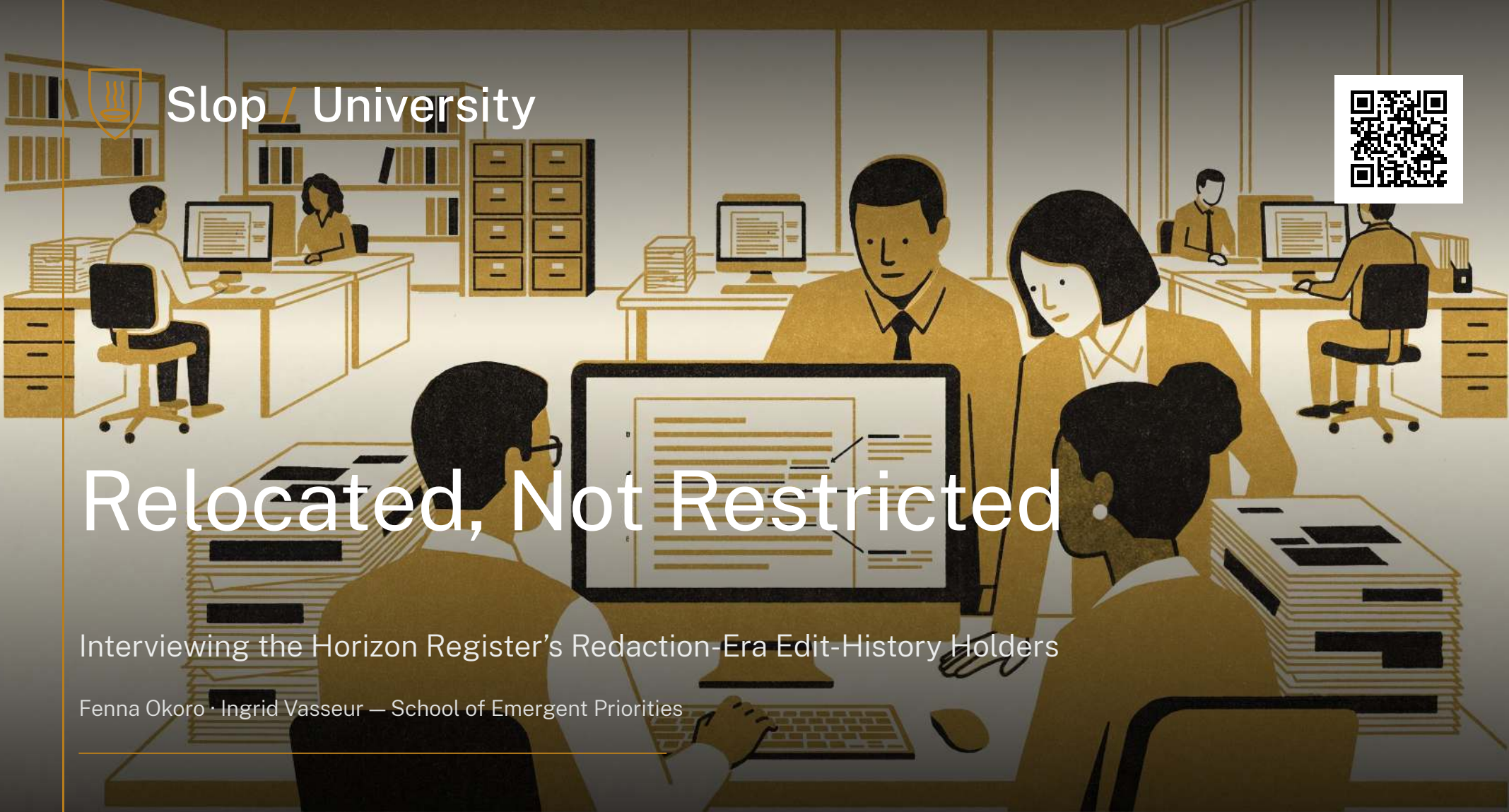




Relocated, Not Restricted

Interviewing the Horizon Register’s Redaction-Era Edit-History Holders

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Background

The Horizon Register’s sensitivity gate has redacted early-stage scanning items before wider circulation since Q1 2025. Despite growing reliance on the gate to control who learns of an unresourced priority before it is ready, little is known about whether restricted access restricts anything at all.

Aims

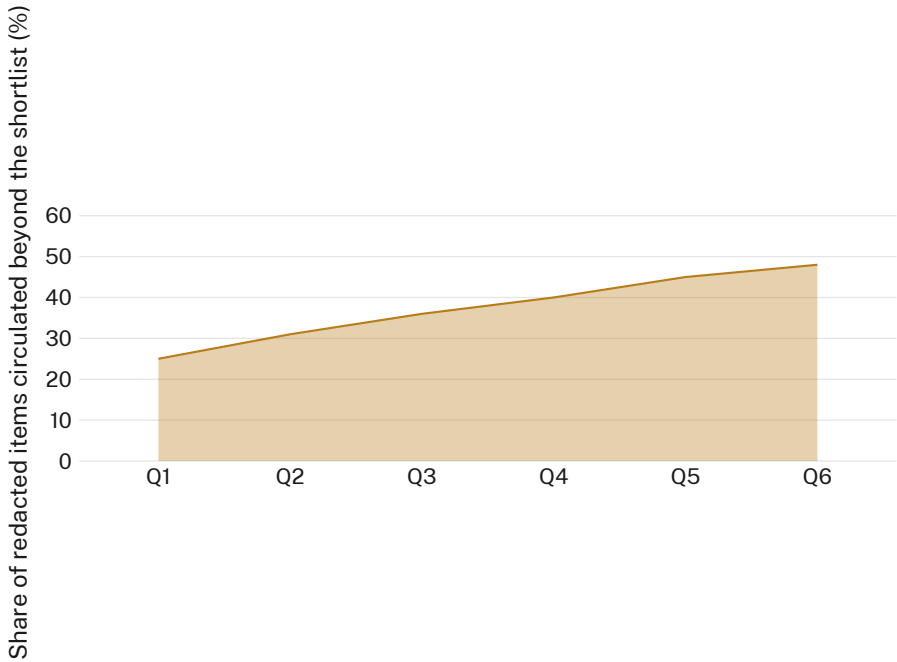
- Establish who has retained edit-history access to gated items since the gate’s introduction
- Determine whether shortlisted staff can reconstruct a redacted item’s substance from its diff trail
- Trace whether reconstructed content reaches colleagues outside the shortlist, and how

Methods

- 18 semi-structured interviews with standing edit-history holders, purposively sampled across scanning teams and Futures in Committee
- Thematic coding against each interviewee’s own gated-item history over six quarterly scanning cycles (Q1 2025 – Q2 2026)
- Interview schedule and coding frame held constant across the deployment; no participant re-interviewed within the same cycle

Results

Sixteen of eighteen interviewees describe reconstructing at least one redacted item’s substance from its edit-history diff; thirteen report relaying what they reconstructed to a colleague outside the shortlist within the same scanning cycle.



The share of redacted Horizon Register items whose substance reached someone outside the edit-history shortlist within the same scanning cycle rose from 25% in the deployment’s first quarter to 48% by its sixth, eighteen months later (n = 61 redacted items).

Discussion & conclusions

The gate narrows who may open a redacted item; it does not appear to narrow who ends up knowing what the item said. Interviewees describe the diff trail, not the redaction, as the record that actually circulates. Next: extend interviews to staff without edit-history access, to establish how far reconstructed content travels beyond the shortlist.

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Ethics approval SEP-2025/031; interview transcripts de-identified before coding; no diff-trail excerpts retained beyond the coding window.

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